OBITUARY

EVERYONE'S OWN

Assam mourns a singer who spoke the language of its soul

By **Kaushik Deka**

A SINGER DROWNS IN FOREIGN WATERS. When his body returns, a deluge of grief swamps his homeland. Three lakh people join the cortège. Over two days and nights, half a million souls file past his coffin. The elderly weep alongside teenagers; bureaucrats stand shoulder to shoulder with tea vendors; police officers, trained in stoicism, sob openly. The dam had finally burst, and now they were crying a river.

When the news first came, a strange stillness had descended upon Assam. Zubeen Garg, their most cherished cultural icon for three decades, was dead. Shops downed shutters, schools emptied, offices fell silent, food delivery services ceased operations, ride-sharing apps went still. Then, before the official word on state mourning—eventually lasting three days—the people began enacting their own rituals of grief. Candles flickered at street corners, oil lamps burned before portraits, crowds sang the song he had asked them to sing when he departed. The chief minister himself flew to Delhi to receive the body, knelt before the coffin, and sang through tears. Modern India had witnessed nothing quite like this.

ZUBEEN GARG (1972-2025)

BIJU BORO

To understand why an entire state ground to a halt for a musician requires an empathic feel for what Zubeen represented to Assam: not merely entertainment, but identity itself. In a region that has long felt unheard within India's vast soundscape, where culture and language were held close as life-giving incantations amidst a generations-long spell of political and economic darkness, Zubeen came like a source of light dressed up as sound. A voice that could speak to poor farmers and software engineers with equal authenticity, that could carry Assamese culture to Bollywood without genuflecting to it.

Born in 1972 in Meghalaya's Tura, raised in Jorhat during Assam's tumultuous years, Zubeen's art emerged from soil watered by both tradition and trauma. It was amazing how that travelled like light across the waters. Over three decades, he would record thousands of songs—in 40 languages. In a way, this duplet rhythm came naturally to him. Beginning with his 1992 debut album *Anamika*, he had not only embodied a generational shift but one that was borne along on a twin axis: a new universality, but from a rooted place. His was music that honoured the sacred *borgeets* of Srimanta Sankardev while embracing electric guitars, that could pivot from a sprightly folk tune to film pop, that lent as much soul to a devotional hymn as to a rebellious anthem.

The last was no pretension. During the anti-CAA protests in 2019, Zubeen wasn't issuing statements from comfortable studios. He stood among the crowds at Latasil field. He possessed that rarest of qualities in modern celebhood: genuine accessibility. Tea-stall conversations, impromptu street gigs, unguarded appearances...he moved through Assamese society not as a visitor from fame's stratosphere but as a permanent resident of its everyday struggles.

His contradictions and stubbornness were legendary and, paradoxically, enhanced rather than diminished his stature. He could arrive at concerts hours late, sometimes intoxicated, yet audiences forgave what they would condemn in others. A Brahmin himself, he publicly challenged Brahminical orthodoxy, faced FIRs for perceived slights to tradition, defied an ULFA diktat against Hindi songs at Bihu festivals, yet remained unscathed. In his defiance, people perhaps realised their own suppressed rebellions; in his excesses, their own human frailties.

Urban youth, the farmer in the outback, the diasporic Assamese, he could speak to them all—as if he was all of them. His Bollywood outings, beginning from a Rahman song in *Dil Se* to the 2016 hit 'Ya Ali', earned him national recognition. But unlike those who drowned in Mumbai's glitter, he always returned to Guwahati, to Assamese cinema, to the local recording studio where it all began. A flowing river, he always curled back to Assam's inner sea. ■